



The sustainable development goals and education, achievements and opportunities

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ABSTRACT

This paper discusses how SDG4 augmented the aspirations contained in the MDGs for education, restoring some of the ambitions which had been articulated by the Education for All Process. The paper examines how much progress SDG4 stimulated, arguing that it yielded: a) progress towards the targets resulting from governments' efforts, b) more ambitious priorities for development organizations, c) reporting on those targets by international organizations, and d) adoption of those targets to shape strategies of universities. The paper then discusses whether SDG4 is still the right goal, examining elements of the goal not yet included in the benchmarks which have been developed to monitor progress. Lastly the paper examines what is missing from the goal, suggesting that new global challenges—war and violence, democratic decline and challenges to human rights—require revisions to SDG4.

The adoption of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) at the UN General Assembly in 2015 represented a quantum leap in framing a development compact to stimulate cooperation and coherence across development efforts. Relative to their predecessor, the Millennium Development Goals (MDGs), the seventeen SDGs and 169 targets were more ambitious, capacious, and challenging, reflecting a multidimensional view of development, and one that required multistakeholder coordination.

The consultative process through which they were developed, reflecting a broad ranges of perspectives that included not just the views of governments, but of civil society, business, and academics, predictably raised the levels of aspirations for what development cooperation should achieve. Predictably also, such heightened aspirations caused concern among development practitioners regarding whether such ambitions could be met, whether they were commensurate with the level of resources available to fund them, whether some of them were measurable or even realizable.

Eight years since their adoption, this article examines three questions with respect to SDG4, Quality Education: How much progress did it stimulate? Is it still the right goal? What challenges remain?

1. How much progress did SDG 4 stimulate?

SDG4 “Ensuring inclusive and equitable quality education and promote lifelong learning opportunities for all” is not only more ambitious but represents a different order of aspirations than the two educational aspirations of the Millennium Development Goals, which included one education goal (universal primary education), and eliminating gender disparity in primary and secondary education, as a target of the goal of promoting gender equality. The SDGs represented a course correction from the MDGs which had narrowed the global education priorities from ‘Basic Education’, articulated in the Education for All Process,¹ to ‘Primary Education’.

The seven targets and three means of implementation of SDG4 encompass universal and equitable quality primary and secondary education, early childhood education, equal access to technical and higher education for all women and men, increase in the number of young people with job readiness, elimination of gender disparities in education and the elimination of barriers based on disability, indigenous status and vulnerability, adult literacy and numeracy, knowledge and skills to promote sustainable development, including human rights, gender

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¹ This process started with the organization of the Education for All Conference in Jomtien, Thailand, in 1990, by major international education organizations including UNESCO, UNICEF, the World Bank and bilateral agencies, to reignite interest in education, after the ‘lost decade’ of the 1990s. The EFA emphasized ‘basic education’ and six key education goals (a) comprehensive early childhood care and education, (b) universal completion of quality primary education for all by 2015 (c) meeting learning needs of all young people and adults; (d) 50% improvement in adult literacy by 2015 (e) eliminate gender disparities in primary and secondary education by 2005; and (f) improve all aspects of the quality of education especially in literacy, numeracy and essential life skills.

equality, peace and non-violence, global citizenship, the three means of implementation include accessibility in education facilities, increase in higher education scholarships for developing countries, increase in supply of qualified teachers. Furthermore, SDG4 was seen as foundational to all other sixteen SDGs. Five key topics of the Education 2030 Framework for Action provide guidance for development priorities: Inclusive and equitable quality education, Lifelong learning, Education for sustainable development and global citizenship, Strong education systems and Partnerships.

The first achievement of SDG4 was to raise the level of aspirations for educational development, bringing them more in line with the aspirations that led to the inclusion of the right to education in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, establishing the aspiration that education should prepare people to uphold human rights and a world order which worked towards advancing those rights for all.

SDG4 has not been achieved in the same way that article 26, the right to education, contained in the Universal Declaration has not been achieved, and in the same way that the Education for All Goals have not been achieved.² As political goals, the nature of the SDGs is such that they are more likely to remain a work in progress than to ever be fully achieved, even as they animate a process of setting specific targets that can drive government efforts towards the achievement of the goals.³ This gap between the level of aspiration of the goals and specific targets and indicators has been evident since the earliest efforts to develop dashboards and benchmarking instruments to monitor the SDG process. For example, an independent effort to develop an SDG Index and Dashboard by the Bertelsmann Stiftung Foundation and by the Sustainable Development Solutions Network, built an index to measure achievement of SDG4 that incorporated Net primary school enrolment rates, Expected years of schooling, Literacy rate of 15–24 year olds, Population with tertiary education and PISA scores (in practice, relying only on three of these indicators for countries in the global south because of data limitations) (Bertelsmann Stiftung and Sustainable Development Solutions Network, 2017).

But the tensions around the relationship between the SDGs and targets and benchmarks, reflect not only the challenges of producing operational definitions of ambitious goals such as ‘global citizenship education’ or ‘education for sustainability’ but also competing views on the role of international development agencies vs. governments in defining specific development targets and strategies. The MDGs reflected a top-down view of development with specific targets defined by international development institutions, while the Education for All and other development efforts, particularly those led by UNESCO, reflected a view more open to local leadership from governments. The SDGs straddle between these two positions of localization vs. top-down development, particularly with respect to the role of targets, benchmarks, and accountability.

A goal such as ‘Ensuring inclusive and equitable quality education and promoting lifelong learning opportunities for all’ needs to be translated into specific targets which draw their significance from time and place. Inclusive and equitable education is contingent on the requirements to participate in society at a given time, and as societies change, the achievements in that goal in the past, become only the foundation of higher aspirations for the future. In a context where the

highest level of education most people complete is elementary education, a focus on inclusion and equity can be on barriers to entry, learning and progression and that level. As secondary education begins to become a requirement for participation in the economy or society, the aspiration of inclusion needs to shift to transition to that level, learning and completion. The same is true for the competencies that educational institutions should develop. In a world in which basic literacy skills provide adequate opportunities to participate economically and civically, inclusion and equity should focus on ensuring such basic literacy, but as participating civically requires understanding more complex information, for example how a virus spreads during a pandemic, or the processes that lead to climate change and can help mitigate, adapt and revert to it, the literacy standards need to be elevated to permit such participation.

This recognition of the need to contextualize the SDGs to specific time and place is the reason the Education 2030 framework for action called for the development of national benchmarks. Led by UNESCO, the benchmarking process reached agreement on seven indicators only by 2019. By 2021/22 three in four countries had adopted such benchmarks with respect to seven of the SDG4 indicators (UNESCO, 2023). The benchmark indicators contain only seven indicators in five domains (early education, basic education, equity, quality, and financing). For early education the indicator is participation rate in pre-primary education, for basic education they are out of school rate, completion rate and learning proficiency, for equity gender gap in completion, for quality trained teachers, and for finance education spending as a percentage of total public spending and of GDP. There are no benchmark indicators yet for target 4.3. technical and vocational education, higher education, adult education, for target 4.4. skills for work, for target 4.6. adult literacy and for target 4.7. education for sustainable development, or for any of the three means for implementation: learning environments, scholarships, and teachers. Except for the indicator for learning, which measures an educational output, all other indicators are input (resources, teacher qualifications) or process indicators (out of school, completion, participation, gender gap). The benchmark indicators need to be expanded to reflect the full set of education targets and to measure education outputs and outcomes or results or they risk reducing their ambition.

The impact of SDG4 on education globally is visible in at least four domains: a) progress towards the targets resulting from governments’ efforts, b) more ambitious priorities for development organizations, c) reporting on those targets by international organizations, and d) adoption of those targets to shape strategies of universities.

SDG4’s focus on learning has stimulated much progress on recognizing foundational literacy and math as important cornerstones of subsequent learning as illustrated by the Global Proficiency Framework developed by UNESCO and other development partners (UNESCO, 2020). Importantly, SDG4 has also animated progress beyond foundational literacy, including efforts to broaden the curricula of various countries to address sustainability, global citizenship, and human rights (UNESCO, 2016 and UNESCO, 2021) and efforts to advance inclusion in education to students with special learning needs.

The Global Monitoring Report produced annually by UNESCO, which reports on progress towards the SDGs, is indicative both of progress towards SDG4, as well as support towards achieving more ambitious goals. This report analyzes each year the most recent statistics available for each country and includes chapters reporting on the education targets of SDG4. Each year, there is a thematic focus on one of the targets, which synthesizes an extensive body of research and reports relevant to that target, in this way advancing public knowledge on the state of the art with respect to that target and with policy options to make progress.

The various Global Monitoring Reports document progress in enrollments, and decrease in out of school children, in gender parity and in early childhood education. However, a recent report examining whether the rate of progress changed since the adoption of SDG4 with respect to

² It should be noted that it was the dissatisfaction with the results achieved by the EFA process during the 1990s, along with competition for control of the development agenda among different UN agencies, that led to the articulation with the MDGs, to be supported by the Fast Track Initiative, as the financing mechanism.

³ The gap between ‘political’ development goals and technical forecasts of what is feasible is not unique to the SDGs, another example is the goal of containing the rise of global temperatures to 1.5 degrees centigrade above pre-industrial levels, used by the International Panel on Climate Change and other entities concerned with climate change.

early childhood education, shows this is the case almost exclusively in high income countries, but not in low- and middle-income countries (UNESCO, 2023). Such analyses and evidence are lacking with respect to quality education or integrating sustainable development in the curriculum. The financing requirements to sustain SDG4 are also lacking in most countries.

The capacious nature of SDG4 to invite partnership across a range of institutions is visible in the growing number of universities which adopt the SDGs as part of their strategies. A recent effort of the Times Higher Education reports on universities efforts with respect to the SDGs in a novel set of Impact Rankings, and 1406 institutions in 106 countries participated in the last round in 2022 (Times Higher Education, 2022).

2. Is SDG4 still the right goal for education?

SDG4 can be challenged both because it covers too much, and because it does not cover enough. The notion that development goals should be defined by international agencies can also be challenged.

With respect to the MDGs for education, focusing on enrollments, SDG4 is certainly more challenging, not just in terms of what it proposes should be prioritized, but also in the requirements to develop metrics for all that it covers. Such metrics are still not available, and, in practice, as mentioned earlier, the development of such metrics has prioritized early childhood education and foundational literacy and math. The idea that 'what is measured is what gets done' might lead some to favor a minimalist, perhaps pragmatic, view that reduces SDG4 to those elements of the goal. This course of action would be misguided for it misses the important role of development goals in building consensus among a broad range of stakeholders and in inspiring collaboration across multiple dimensions of the educational process. While narrow and well-defined and measurable goals may suit the needs of project managers and even of specific agencies, they do not serve the development collective well. A goal such as 'enrollment in primary education' or 'early grade literacy' may be useful to the chief of party of a donor funded project, and to donor agencies who need to report progress to their funders, but not be as useful to motivate a minister of finance, or a Cabinet, in allocating resources for education in a context of many competing priorities. In contrast a goal such as 'educating for sustainable development' is more capacious to invite partnerships between school systems and other institutions, such as universities, private organizations, or diverse ministries. An additional reason a reductionism approach to the SDG4 is misguided is that development is indeed multidimensional and cannot be reduced to a single dimension or metric, as doing so can distort development efforts. Consider, for example, a context in which violence causes rapid displacement of children. Schools that welcome displaced children might very well see their performance in metrics of 'Early Grade Reading' fall, as they work with children with more challenging backgrounds. But in that larger context, it is the inclusion of such children that reflects educational progress.

Furthermore, there is the question of what purpose SDG4 should serve. Unlike the goals and targets of an organization or project, in which achievement of the goals is a function of strategy and execution of a clear delivery system, the Sustainable Development Goals are designed to inspire and coordinate actions among a wide range of autonomous institutions, governmental and non-governmental, national, subnational, local, and translational. These are 'system' goals, not 'project' goals. The 'world system' is more loosely coupled than any organization. While some might prefer tighter 'coupling', directed from the 'top' of the system, others might favor 'looser' coupling with greater voice for national governments and even for sub-national governments or civil society. From these competing viewpoints emerge two views on accountability, one is accountability of governments to international development agencies, the other is accountability of those agencies to the governments, or the societies, on whose behalf development is predicated.

It should be expected that progress towards goals with this greater level of ambition and complexity would be challenging. A development agenda should, after all, be about promoting development, a messy process for sure, not about simplifying the lives of project managers or international development agencies, or specialists. Many distortions to the process of international development are the result of incentive structures faced by governments, development institutions or elected representatives in donor countries. The latter often pressure development agencies to show measurable results in increasingly shorter time frames, so they can satisfy their constituencies. This causes development agencies to commit to development objectives which are short term proxies of dubious predictive value of the long-term process which is development. By this alchemy, development becomes moving the needle in some short-term metric which becomes the surrogate goal. This explains the appeal, but also the myopia, of metrics such as the number of people living below a poverty line, even if such number tells us little about whether those living under or just above those lines live in contexts where conflict, violence, bigotry, discrimination, or abuses from those in power constrain the choices they can make. This is how education, the process designed to develop human potential, becomes access to primary education or 'number of words per minute'. It is easy to forget that the entire global architecture for development is built on the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, understanding that only progress towards a compact that recognized the fundamental equality and dignity of all humans would guarantee global peace and security. That we have come to accept that simply extricating people from the abject conditions represented by living under the level of income necessary to keep their bodies functioning is a worthy goal, speaks about a poverty of aspirations and moral commitments which makes us complicit with a world in which respect for human rights is declining and under siege in the global north as well as the global south. Focusing very narrowly on goals such as early grade reading, without attention to what it is that children are learning that will help them address violence in their communities or hold their governments accountable is unlikely to do much to expand their freedoms and opportunities.

Capacious as it is, SDG4 is also limited, in many ways still reflecting a 'top down' view of development as directed by the United Nations and other development organizations. In contrast, UNESCO's recent report on the Futures of Education underscores the role of civil society, students, parents, and teachers, and of universities in animating a transformation of the culture of education, as well as the importance of lifelong learning, themes which are absent from SDG4 (UNESCO 2021).

3. What challenges remain?

SDG4 is a clear call to make education relevant to the challenges of social inclusion and sustainability. Since its adoption, however, other challenges have become pressing: war and violence, democratic decline and challenges to human rights, and the challenges that Artificial Intelligence will create for social inclusion. If the goal of SDG4 is to be to mobilize a broad-based consensus on the importance of education, it must address how education addresses those critical development challenges.

The other big shift, since the SDGs were adopted, was the crisis unleashed by the COVID-19 pandemic. This crisis made visible fractures and vulnerabilities of education systems and underscored the limitations in institutional capacity of education systems to sustain educational opportunity during the pandemic, and to redress its impact in learning. Most countries are still struggling to recover from the crisis. Given this, it might be reasonable to expect pressures to reduce educational expectations, a return to a minimalist approach. This path could well undo the progress which SDG4 represented in taking development efforts beyond the basics of primary school enrollment.

In elevating the aspirations for what skills learners should gain as a result of being educated, SDG4 shed light on the important topic of institutional capacity and teacher capacity. Tackling that goal, rather

than eschewing it in favor of reduced goals and metrics, is essential to deliver progress and human flourishing. Perhaps the answer to address this conundrum continues to be in partnerships for development, SDG17, including the partnerships between universities and school systems that the report 'Reimagining Our Futures Together' calls for and the partnerships with other institutions that result in the 'whole of society' effort that the SDGs were intended to animate.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Fernando M. Reimers: Conceptualization, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing.

Conflicts of interest statement

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence

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